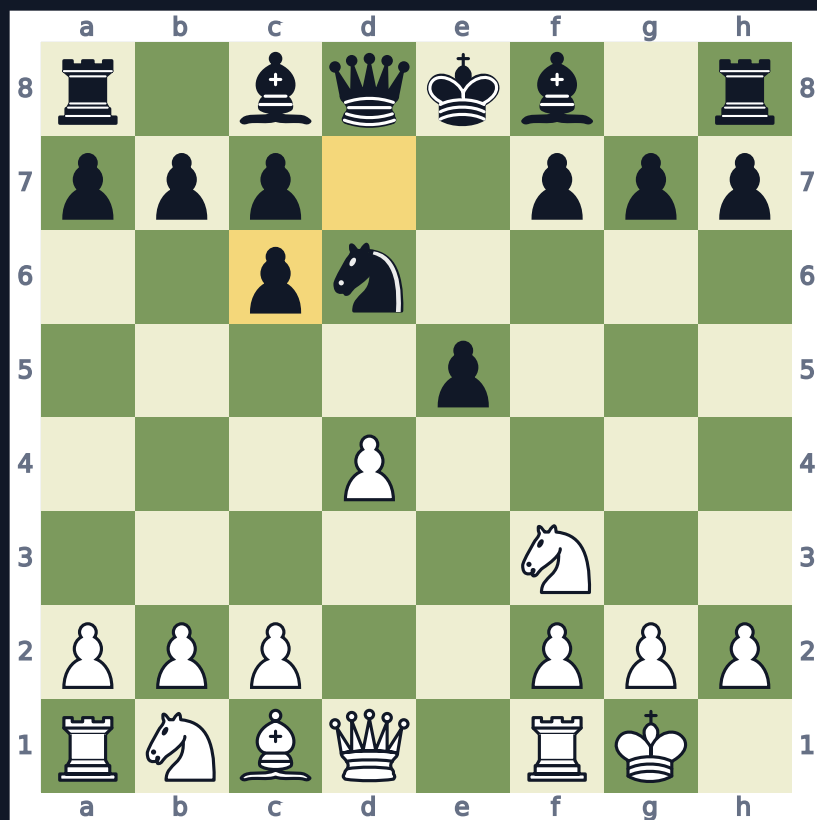


09

The Berlin Defense

The queenless middlegame, Black's uncastled king, and the battle between structure and bishops.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will play both sides of the Berlin with active plans instead of treating it as a mysterious drawing mechanism.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 049 | PAGE 4

Decode: Entering the Berlin endgame*The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.*

LESSON 050 | PAGE 8

Play: Entering the Berlin endgame*The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.*

LESSON 051 | PAGE 12

Decode: Activating the uncastled king*In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.*

LESSON 052 | PAGE 16

Play: Activating the uncastled king*In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.*

LESSON 053 | PAGE 20

Decode: The advanced e5 pawn*An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.*

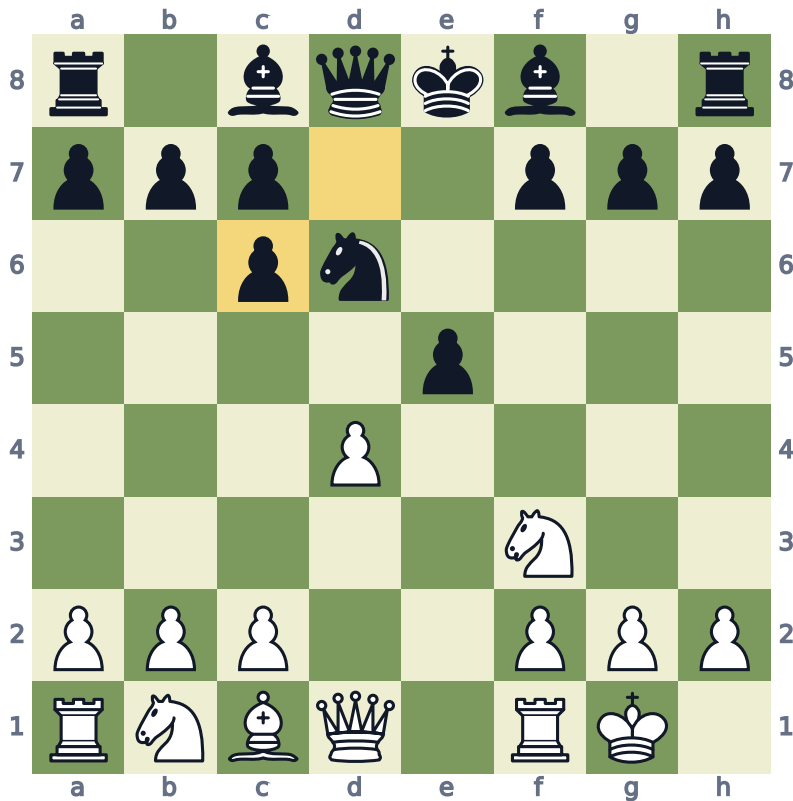
LESSON 054 | PAGE 24

Play: The advanced e5 pawn*An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will play both sides of the Berlin with active plans instead of treating it as a mysterious drawing mechanism.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Entering the Berlin endgame



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

DECISION RULE

Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black activates the king and bishops, connects rooks, and undermines e5 before White consolidates.

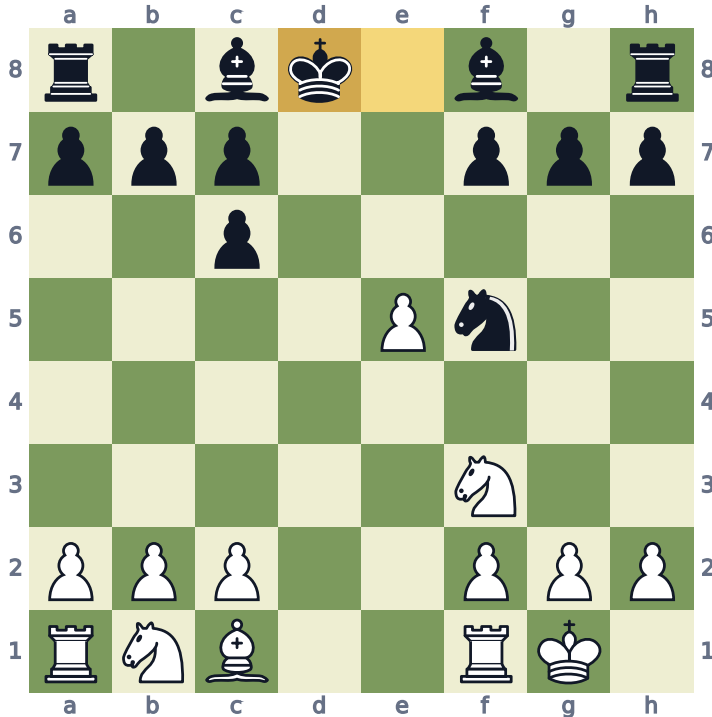
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority.

MEMORY RULE | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black activates the king and bishops, connects rooks, and undermines e5 before White consolidates.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority.

FAILURE MODE

Playing automatically because the queens are gone and allowing the opponent's strategic asset to mature.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

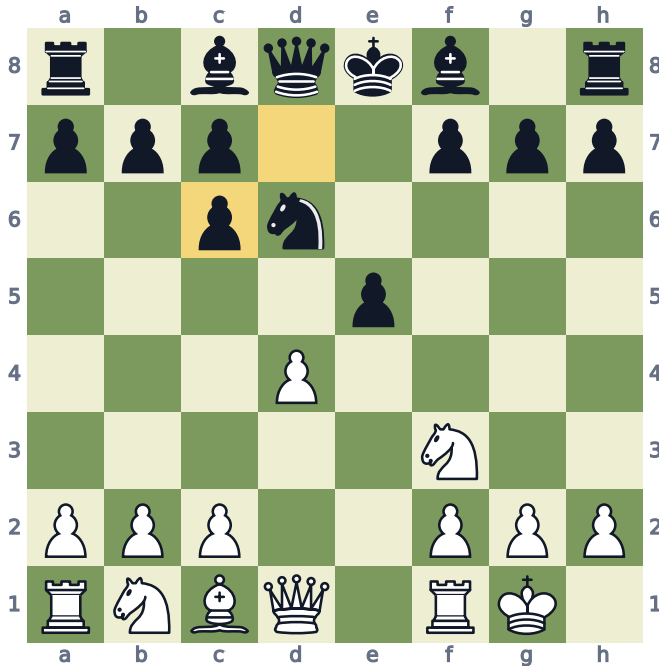
RULE | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Nd6: Black reroutes a knight to d6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bxc6: White releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxc6: Black releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority? White's resource is: White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority. The line fails as a template when: Playing automatically because the queens are gone and allowing the opponent's strategic asset to mature.

STORE THIS | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

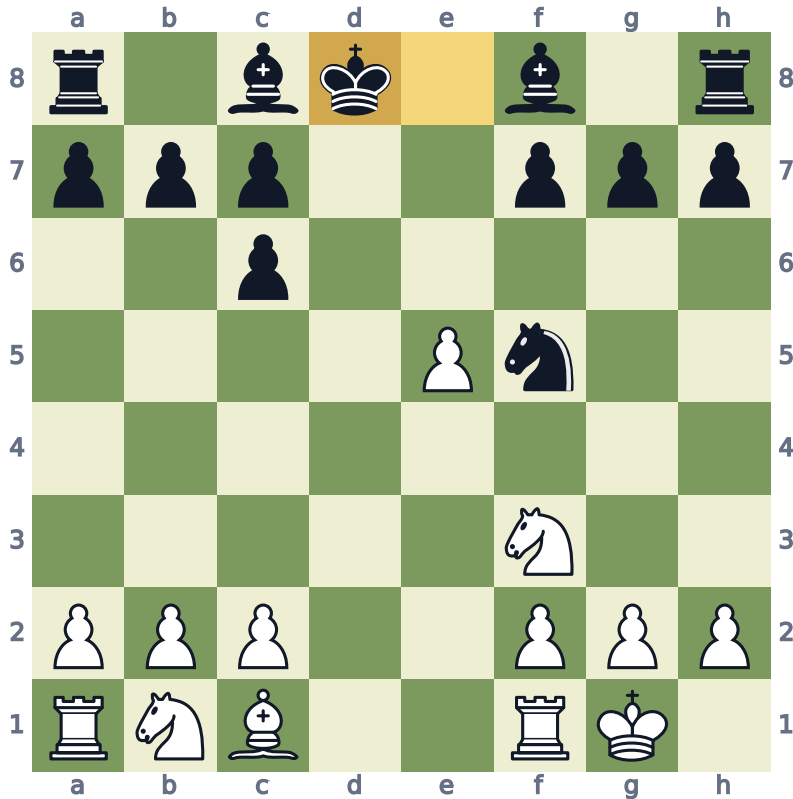
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Entering the Berlin endgame



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

DECISION RULE

Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black activates the king and bishops, connects rooks, and undermines e5 before White consolidates.

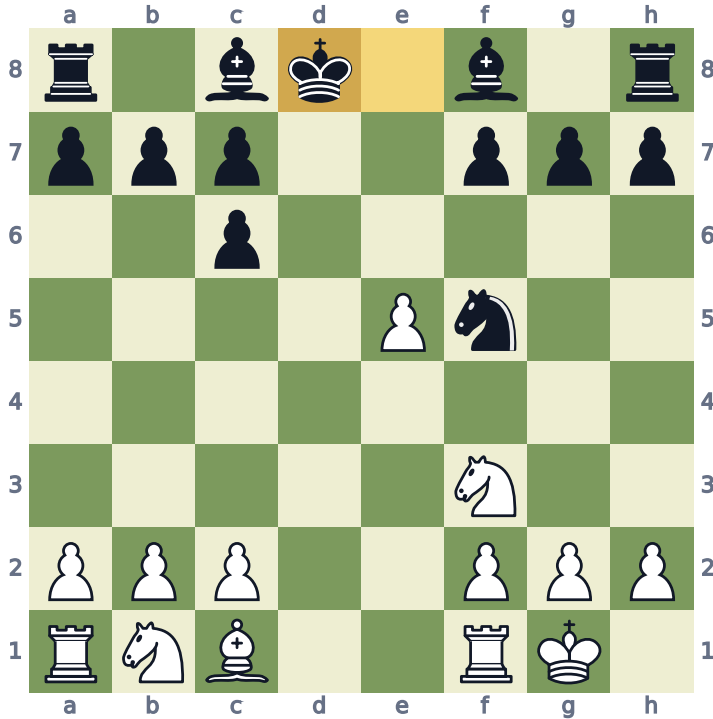
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority.

MEMORY RULE | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black activates the king and bishops, connects rooks, and undermines e5 before White consolidates.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority.

FAILURE MODE

Playing automatically because the queens are gone and allowing the opponent's strategic asset to mature.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

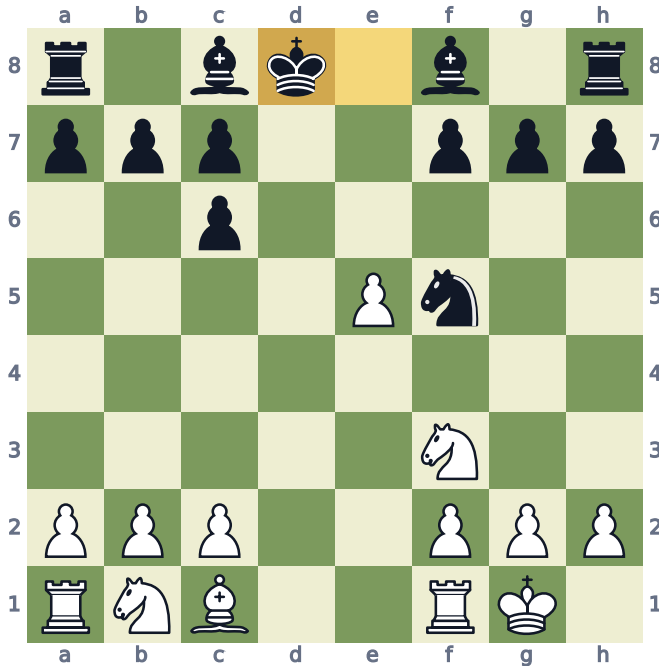
RULE | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8



- Bxc6: White releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxc6: Black releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf5: Black reroutes a knight to f5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Qxd8+: White releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Kxd8: Black releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Queens come off, but the position remains rich: White has better pawns and space; Black has bishops, king activity, and pressure on e5.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority? White's resource is: White restricts the bishops, protects e5 efficiently, and uses the kingside pawn majority. The line fails as a template when: Playing automatically because the queens are gone and allowing the opponent's strategic asset to mature.

STORE THIS | The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

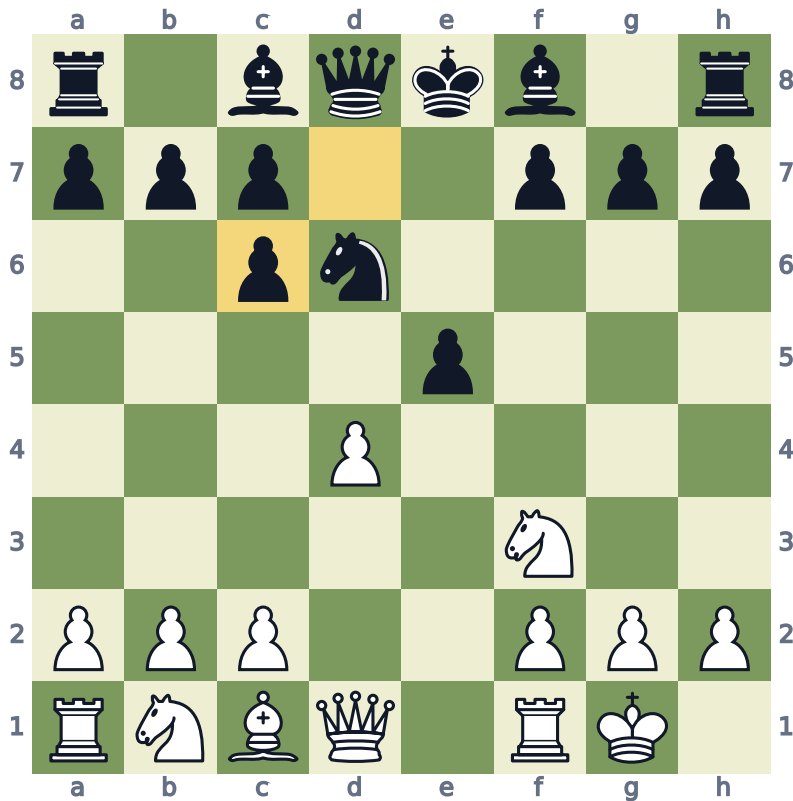
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Activating the uncastled king



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Without queens, the king can walk toward e8 or c8 to connect rooks and defend central squares; lost castling is not automatically lost time.

DECISION RULE

Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Choose the king route that frees the h8 rook and avoids tactical checks or pins.

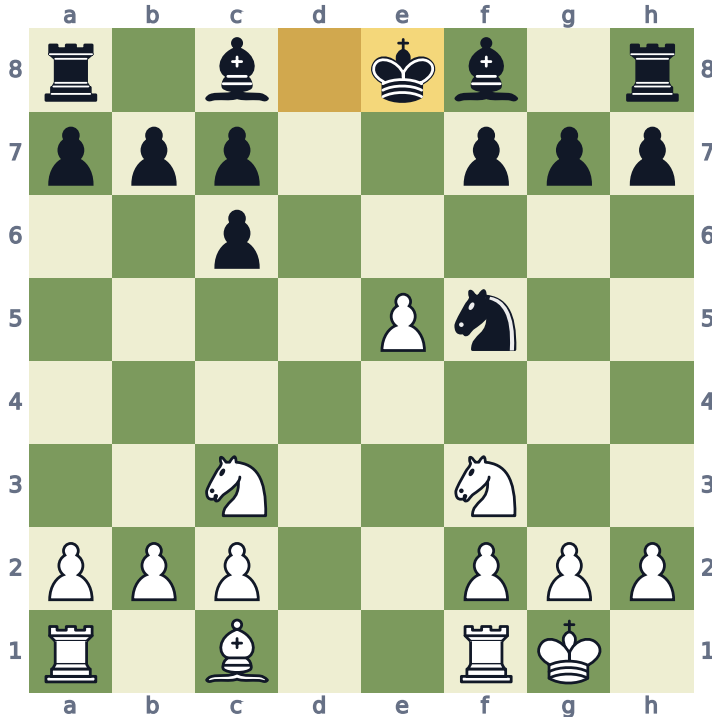
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces.

MEMORY RULE | In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Without queens, the king can walk toward e8 or c8 to connect rooks and defend central squares; lost castling is not automatically lost time.

BLACK'S PLAN

Choose the king route that frees the h8 rook and avoids tactical checks or pins.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces.

FAILURE MODE

Hiding the king as if queens remained, leaving the rook trapped and the position passive.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

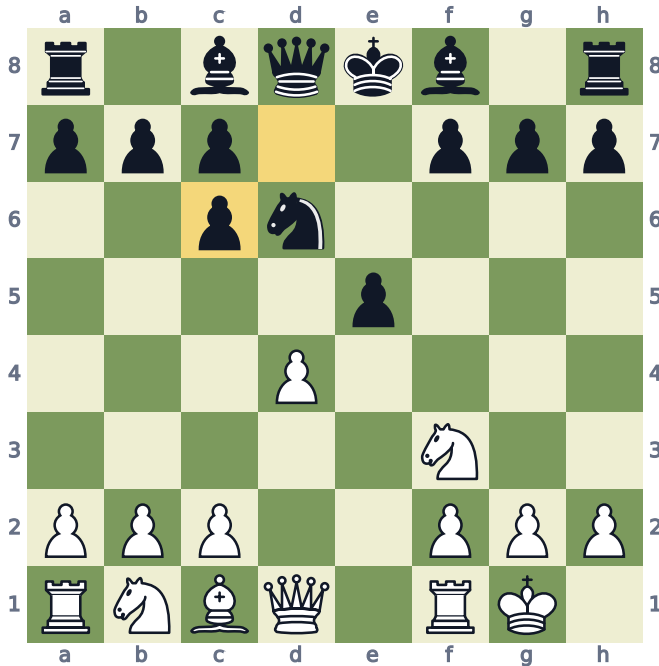
RULE | In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic? White's resource is: White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces. The line fails as a template when: Hiding the king as if queens remained, leaving the rook trapped and the position passive.

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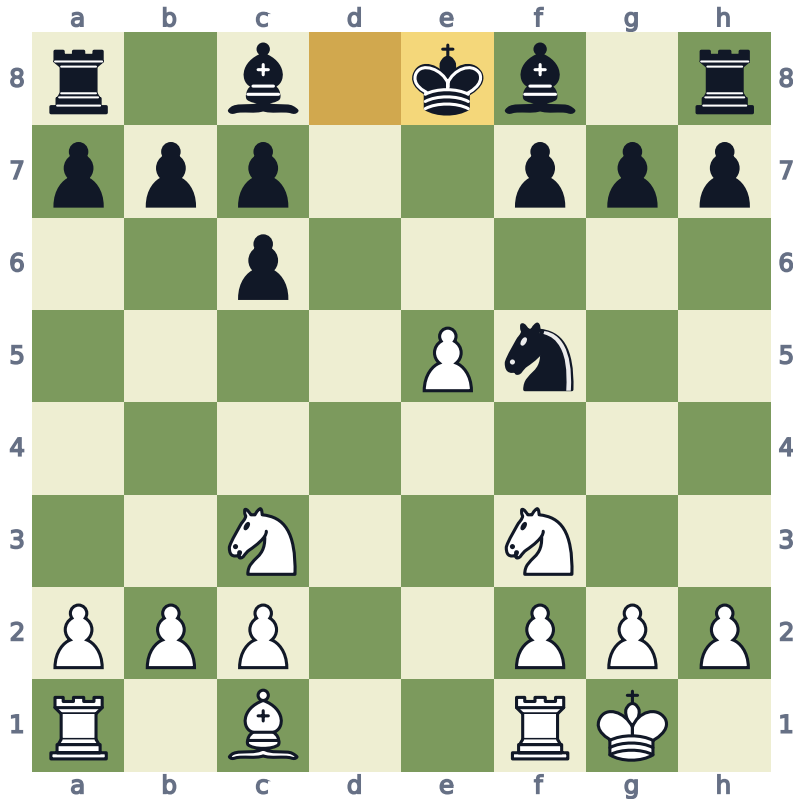
1. Without queens, the king can walk toward e8 or c8 to connect rooks and defend central squares; lost castling is not automatically lost time. 2. Choose the king route that frees the h8 rook and avoids tactical checks or pins. 3. White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces. 4. Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic? 5. Hiding the king as if queens remained, leaving the rook trapped and the position passive.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Activating the uncastled king



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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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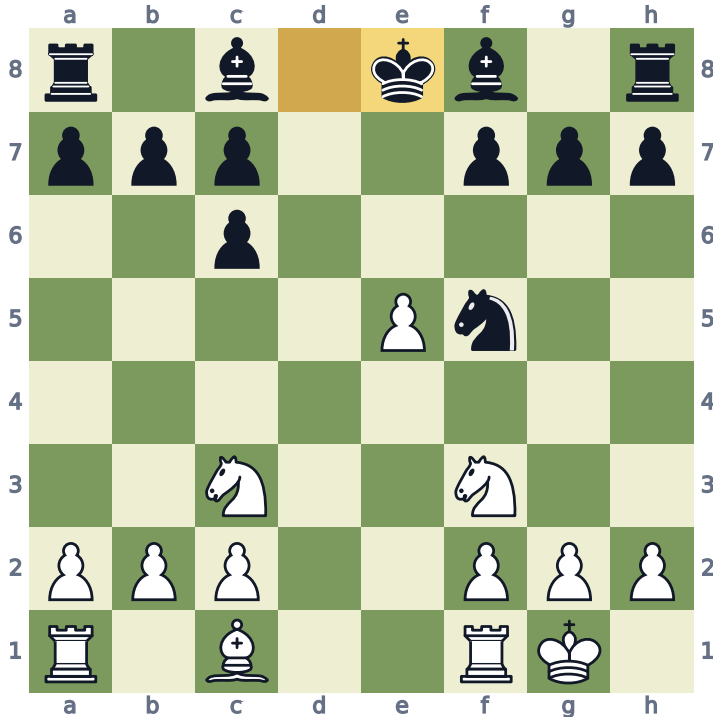
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

Choose the king route that frees the h8 rook and avoids tactical checks or pins.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces.

FAILURE MODE

Hiding the king as if queens remained, leaving the rook trapped and the position passive.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

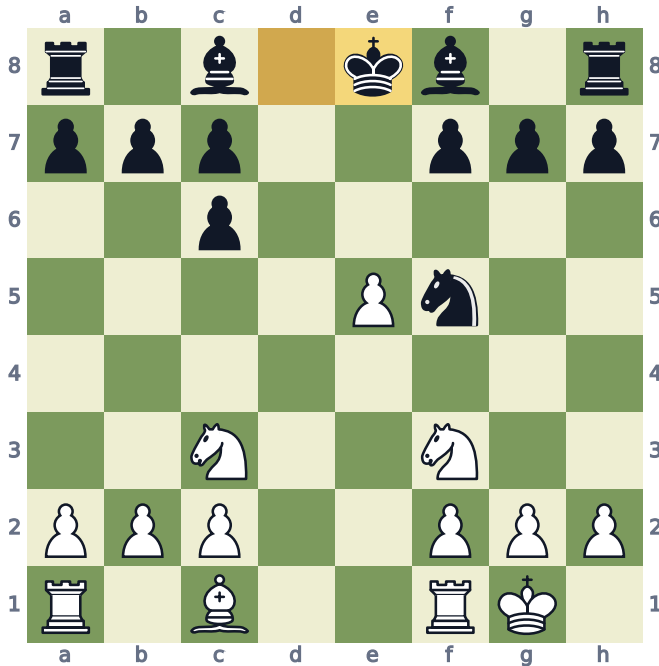
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Ke8



- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf5: Black reroutes a knight to f5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Qxd8+: White releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Kxd8: Black releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Ke8: Black improves coordination and changes the candidate set.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Without queens, the king can walk toward e8 or c8 to connect rooks and defend central squares; lost castling is not automatically lost time.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic? White's resource is: White gains space and tries to prevent easy rook coordination with active minor pieces. The line fails as a template when: Hiding the king as if queens remained, leaving the rook trapped and the position passive.

STORE THIS | In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

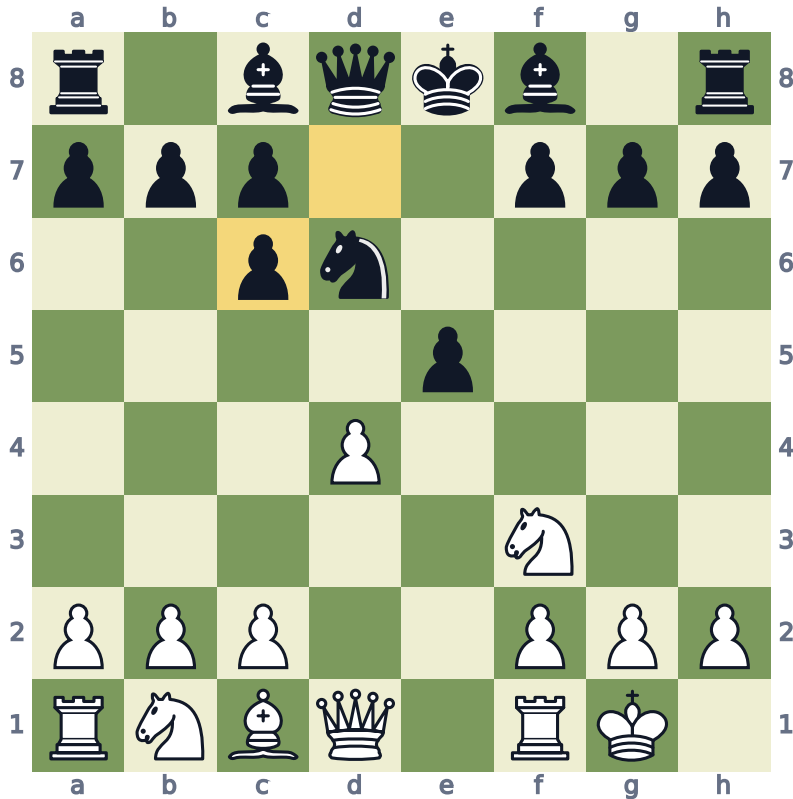
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Ke8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The advanced e5 pawn



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks.

DECISION RULE

Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Attack e5 without becoming tied down, use ...h6 or ...Ke8 as needed, and activate the light bishop.

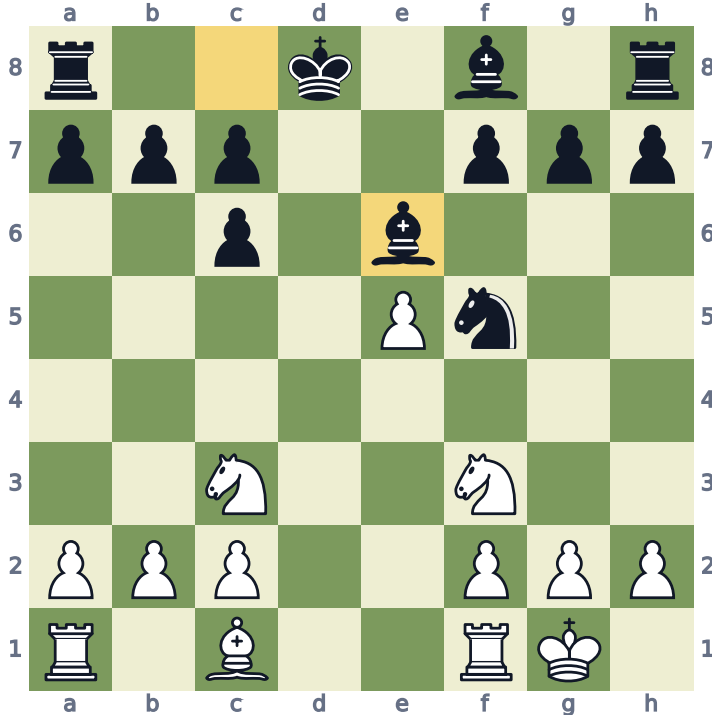
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority.

MEMORY RULE | An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks.

BLACK'S PLAN

Attack e5 without becoming tied down, use ...h6 or ...Ke8 as needed, and activate the light bishop.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority.

FAILURE MODE

Defending or attacking the pawn with too many pieces and surrendering activity elsewhere.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

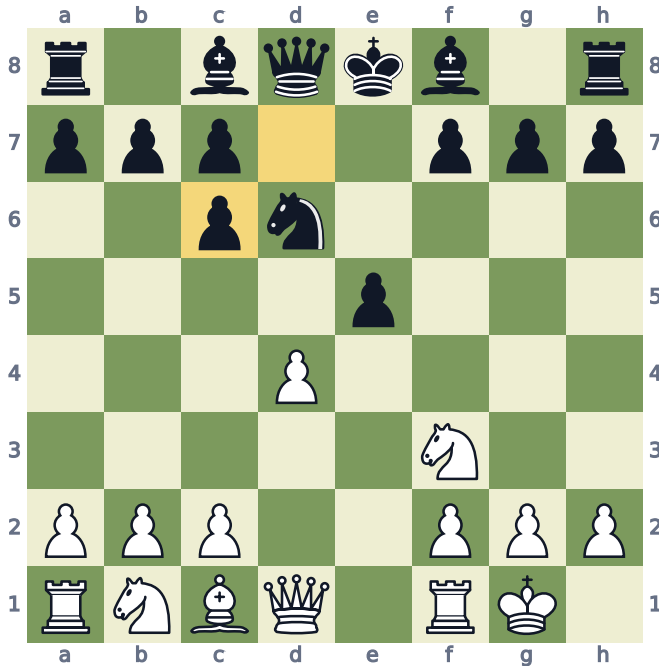
RULE | An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Be6



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Nd6: Black reroutes a knight to d6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded? White's resource is: White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority. The line fails as a template when: Defending or attacking the pawn with too many pieces and surrendering activity elsewhere.

STORE THIS | An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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ANSWER KEY

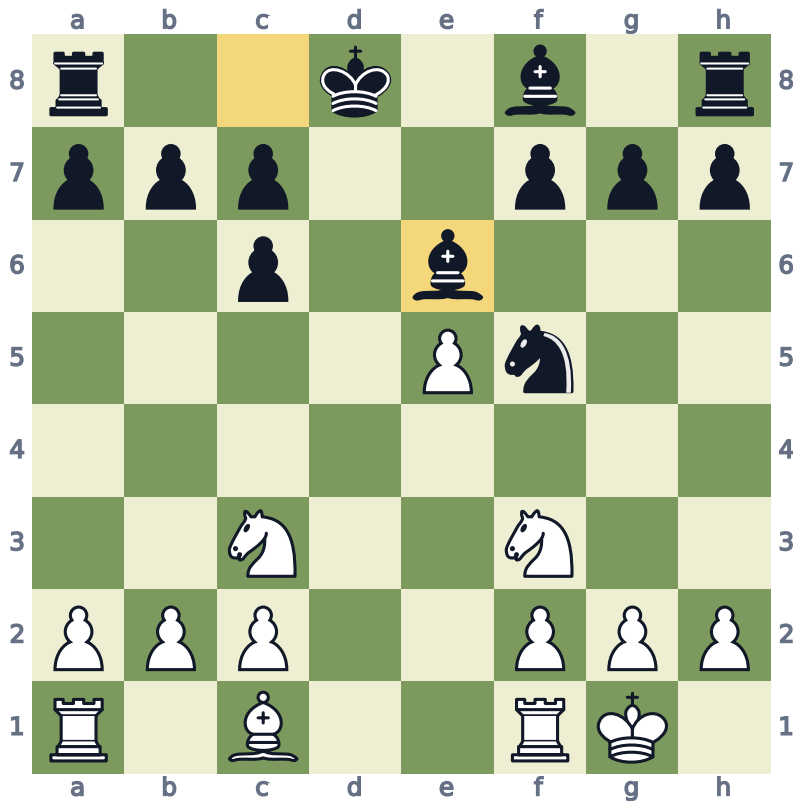
1. White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks. 2. Attack e5 without becoming tied down, use ...h6 or ...Ke8 as needed, and activate the light bishop. 3. White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority. 4. Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded? 5. Defending or attacking the pawn with too many pieces and surrendering activity elsewhere.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The advanced e5 pawn



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks.

DECISION RULE

Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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WHITE'S RESOURCES

White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority.

MEMORY RULE | An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

The plan map

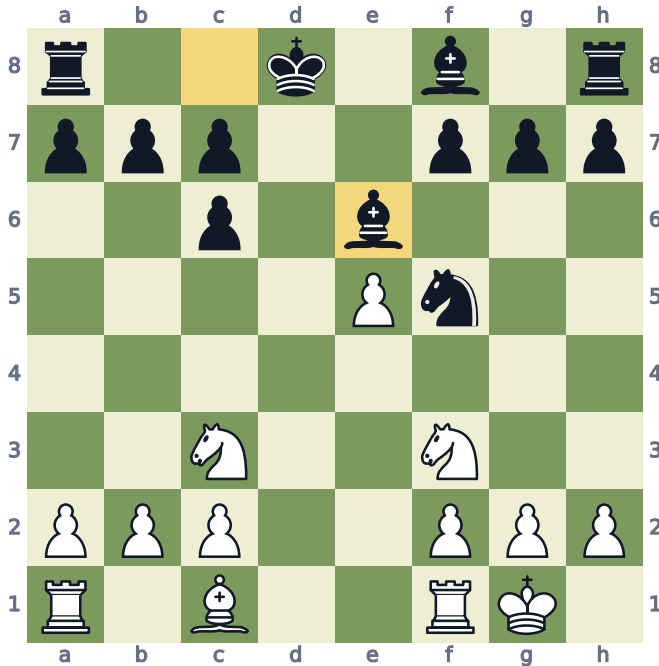


INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Be6



- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf5: Black reroutes a knight to f5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Qxd8+: White releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Kxd8: Black releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded? White's resource is: White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority. The line fails as a template when: Defending or attacking the pawn with too many pieces and surrendering activity elsewhere.

STORE THIS | An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. White's e5 pawn gains space and restricts f6, but it can become a fixed target for bishops, king, and rooks. 2. Attack e5 without becoming tied down, use ...h6 or ...Ke8 as needed, and activate the light bishop. 3. White supports e5 economically and uses the space to improve knights and the kingside majority. 4. Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded? 5. Defending or attacking the pawn with too many pieces and surrendering activity elsewhere.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Be6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 049 Decode: Entering the Berlin endgame

Prompt: Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority?

Recall: *The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.*

LESSON 050 Play: Entering the Berlin endgame

Prompt: Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority?

Recall: *The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.*

LESSON 051 Decode: Activating the uncastled king

Prompt: Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic?

Recall: *In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.*

LESSON 052 Play: Activating the uncastled king

Prompt: Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic?

Recall: *In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.*

LESSON 053 Decode: The advanced e5 pawn

Prompt: Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded?

Recall: *An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.*

LESSON 054 Play: The advanced e5 pawn

Prompt: Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded?

Recall: *An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.*

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Entering the Berlin endgame

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

Decision: Whose slow asset becomes active first: Black's bishops or White's pawn majority?

Memory: The Berlin trades tactical danger for a race between activity and structure.

CARD 2

Activating the uncastled king

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Ke8

Decision: Which king square connects the rooks fastest without blocking a bishop or entering a tactic?

Memory: In queenless play, the king is a piece; activate it with calculation.

CARD 3

The advanced e5 pawn

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. Nc3 Be6

Decision: Is e5 a protected strength or an overextended target, and which defender can be overloaded?

Memory: An advanced pawn is strong when it restricts more pieces than it needs to defend.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
049 Decode: Entering the Berlin endgame	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
050 Play: Entering the Berlin endgame	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
051 Decode: Activating the uncastled king	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
052 Play: Activating the uncastled king	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
053 Decode: The advanced e5 pawn	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
054 Play: The advanced e5 pawn	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.